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Commodity Matters | Europe

Gold on Hold

De-escalation in the Middle East supports gold, but a more hawkish Fed brings challenges, particularly for ETF buying. We still see risks skewed to the upside but our $5,200/oz forecast looks more challenging to achieve without ETF re-engagement.

Key Takeaways

- Middle East progress is a tailwind for gold if lower oil prices ease inflation and external balance pressures.
- Official sector demand remains the strongest structural support. WGC's survey shows 45% of respondents see their gold reserves rising over the next 12 months.
- The Fed is the main near-term constraint. A hawkish hold raises the opportunity cost of holding gold and is likely to matter most through ETF flows.
- We retain an upside bias, but $5,200/oz in 2H26 now looks more dependent on renewed ETF buying and evidence that lower oil is feeding into the rate outlook.

Middle East conflict de-escalation is positive for gold: Gold has not played its traditional safe haven role during the conflict, with supply shocks harder to hedge than demand shocks. The conflict has created 2 headwinds for gold: 1) higher bond yields; 2) pressure on fiscal balances of oil and gas importers, driving some gold sales (e.g. Turkey). Against this backdrop, de-escalation should be supportive. Our oil strategist sees lower oil prices than previously expected, which should ease pressure on central banks either to sell gold or to tighten monetary policy. In the latest WGC central bank survey, a record 45% of respondents expect their gold reserves to increase over the next 12m. China's PBOC has already accelerated purchases, buying 23t between March and May, versus 19t in the previous 12m.

A more hawkish Fed could be a challenge for ETF buying: Our US economists view the latest FOMC statement, projections and press conference as hawkish, and note no reference to downside risks in the labour market. This has pushed rate hike expectations higher, and gold lower. While central bank gold buying may resume regardless, ETF flows are more sensitive to changes in rate expectations.

But with some offsets: Our economists note the inflation path implied by the Summary of Economic Projections may not fully reflect disinflationary forces from a SoH reopening, and sits above their own estimates. They see the Fed on hold through 2026. On top, gold has actually ended 0.84% higher one month after a 25bp hike on average (see grey box inside for more detail).

MS outlook: We still see upside risks for gold from current levels, but the route to $5,200/oz looks more challenging. A durable Middle East de-escalation should ease oil driven inflation pressure, while central bank buying remains structurally supportive. The missing piece is ETF demand, which is likely to remain sensitive to the Fed path, real yields and the dollar.

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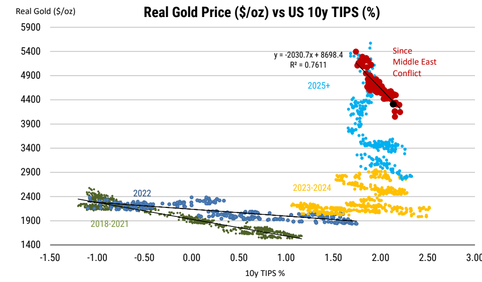
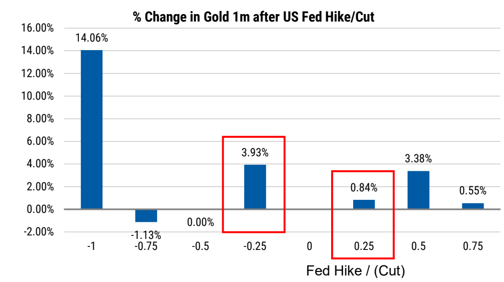
Exhibit 1 : Gold has reconnected with real yields



Source: Bloomberg, Morgan Stanley Research

Exhibit 8 : On average, gold has rallied 0.84% in the 1 month after a 25bp Fed hike versus 3.93% after a cut

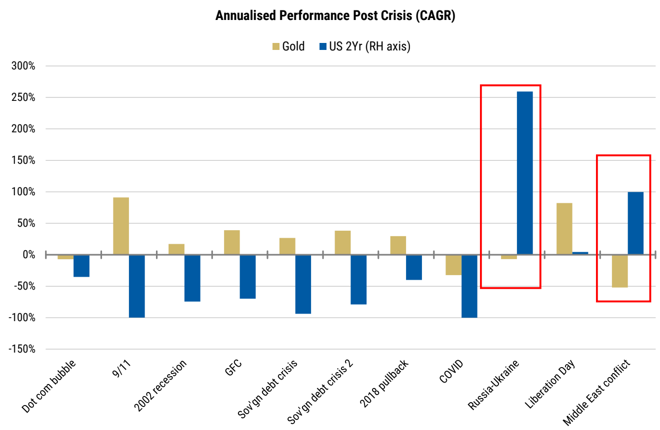


Source: Bloomberg, Morgan Stanley Research

Also see: metal&ROCK: Gold: Safe Haven or Risk Asset? (17 Apr 2026)

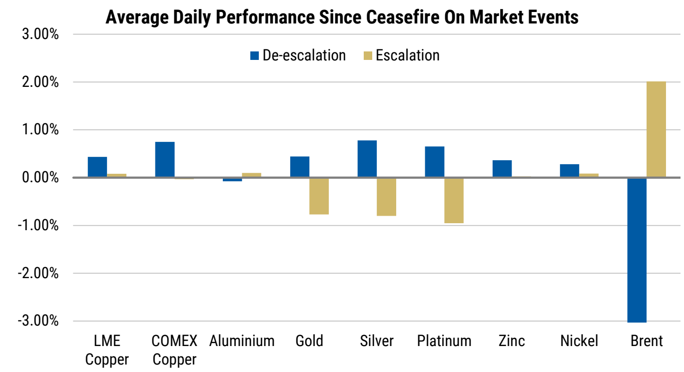
Key Charts

Exhibit 3: Gold is less effective as a safe haven in supply shocks than demand shocks



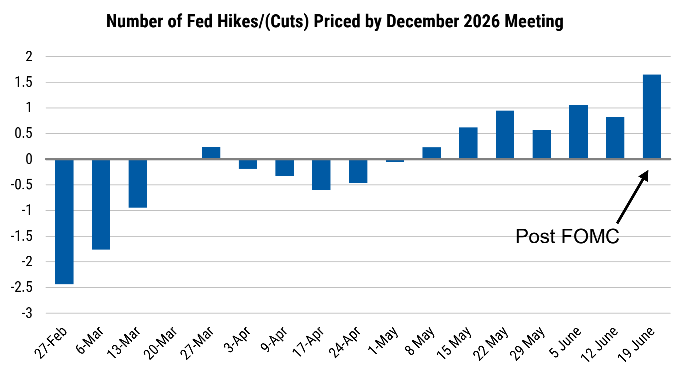
Source: World Gold Council, Morgan Stanley Research

Exhibit 4: And gold has been performing better on de-escalation days



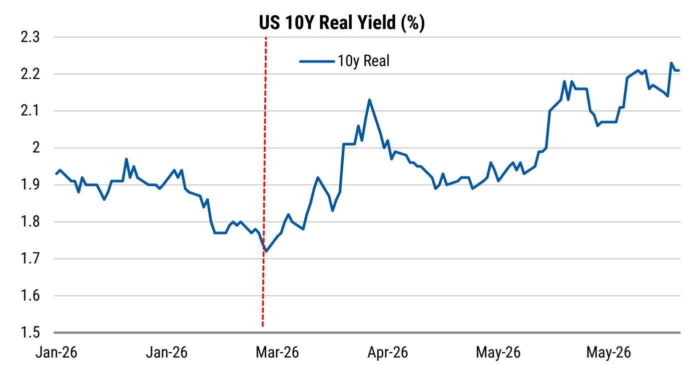
Source: Bloomberg, Morgan Stanley Research

Exhibit 5: The market pricing for Fed rate hikes has increased dramatically



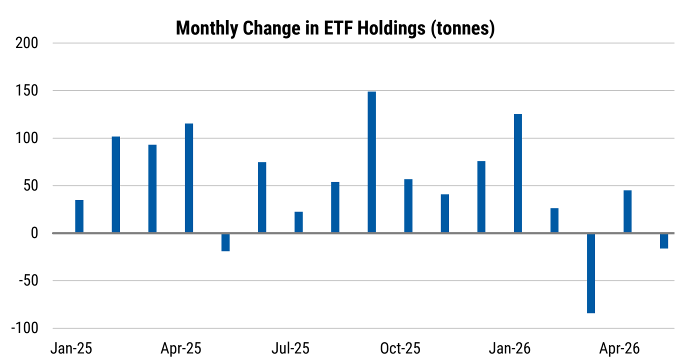
Source: Bloomberg

Exhibit 6: Real yields are still well above February levels



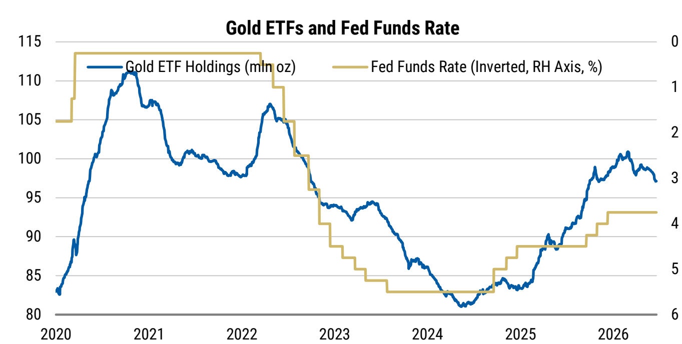
Source: Bloomberg

Exhibit 7: ETFs have been selling some gold with the Fed on hold



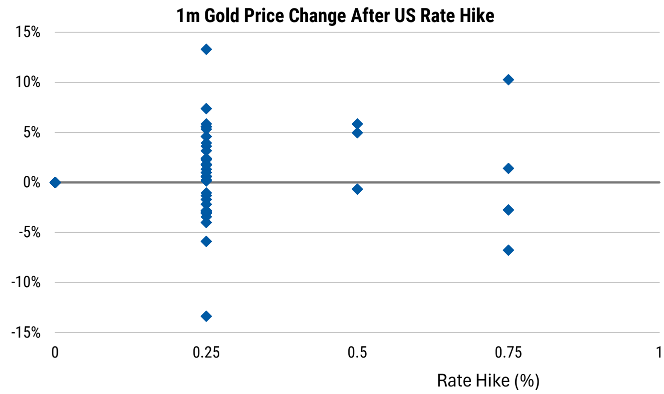
Source: WGC, Morgan Stanley Research

Exhibit 8: ETFs tend to be most active buying gold during rate cutting



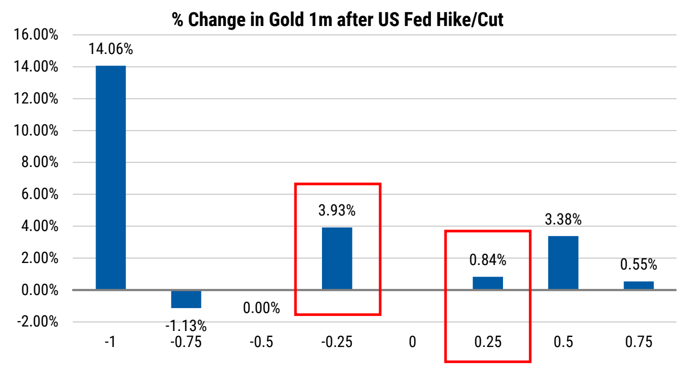
Source: Bloomberg

Exhibit 9: Gold's performance after rate hikes is quite mixed



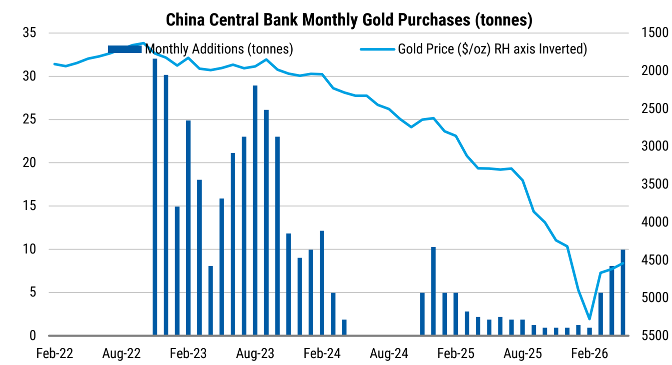
Source: Bloomberg, Morgan Stanley Research

Exhibit 10: On average, gold has rallied 0.84% in the 1 month after a 25bp Fed hike



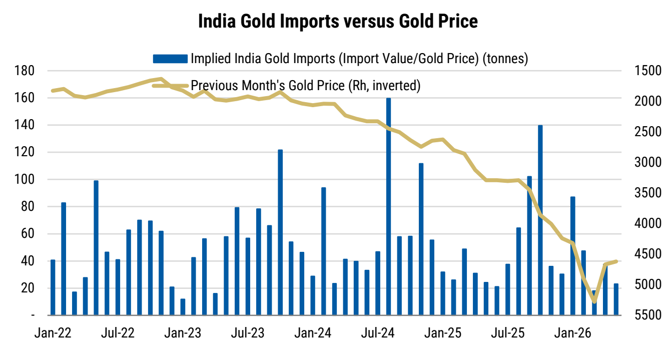
Source: Bloomberg, Morgan Stanley Research

Exhibit 11: China's gold purchases have accelerated with the pullback



Source: Bloomberg

Exhibit 12: India's imports moderated, with the gold import duty hiked during May to discourage purchases



Source: Bloomberg

The World Gold Council highlights several historical examples where gold rallied after a Fed hike:

- Jun 2006: The Fed was hiking into growth concerns, while strong physical demand from ETFs and China was also supporting prices.

- Mar 2017: The rate hike was interpreted as dovish versus expectations and USD weakened, supporting gold.

- Dec 2018: The hike was viewed as a policy error with the Fed returning to cuts in 2019.

- Nov 2022: The hike came against growing market fragility, while the USD weakened.

- Mar 2023: "The Fed tightened into acute banking stress. Long-end yields fell sharply as markets accelerated expectations of a pause and eventual easing."

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	Coverage Universe		Investment Banking Clients (IBC)			Other Material Investment Services Clients (MISC)	
Stock Rating Category	Count	% of Total	Count	% of Total IBC	% of Rating Category	Count	% of Total Other MISC
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Equal-weight/Hold	1571	43%	369	40%	23%	723	44%
Not-Rated/Hold	3	0%	0	0%	0%	1	0%
Underweight/Sell	551	15%	86	9%	16%	201	12%
Total	3,667		920			1632	

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